

BUYING GAME CONSOLES

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It's been a while since I've been pondering whether to get a console. With all three prominent game consoles available in the country, how do you decide which one to buy? I'm not a dogged PC gamer, willing to invest tens of thousands of rupees every other year to keep my rig relevant with upcoming games. So opting for a game console will probably simplify many things and negate the need for timely upgrade cycles. After a browsing session on the Internet, this is what I gathered.

Nintendo Wii

Casual gamers who aren't head over heels into serious gaming should consider Nintendo Wii. Before Microsoft's Xbox 360 Kinect, it was Nintendo Wii which brought controller-free motion-sensing games to the market.

It may not have the best game libraries to tout, nor the best graphics among all consoles available today, nor a mention-worthy online gameplay experience but nothing beats the Nintendo Wii and its collection of party and arcade titles. The Wii remote was revolutionary when launched and can still handle a lot. This platform has also successfully tapped into the fitness games genre. Overall, the Wii recaptures a lost era of gaming when games were simple and fun to play and with the additional motion-sensing element it enlarges the canvas for a small group of casual gamers.

The Nintendo Wii remains the most inexpensive of the three game consoles sold in India. So if you need a family entertainment device for casual gaming,

the Nintendo Wii is a good fit for just over ₹12k (may be even cheaper).

Sony PlayStation 3

The PlayStation 3 (PS3) is now five years old but still remains relevant. Unlike the Nintendo Wii, it's more than just a game console — it's an HD media player. It has a Blu-ray drive and supports stereoscopic 3D gaming. Compared to the Wii and Xbox 360, it boasts of superior internal hardware — the consoles were used to build supercomputers a couple of years ago.



With so much firepower in its belly, the PS3 is undoubtedly one for enthusiast gamers who want to play the latest games, engage in online multiplayer sessions, and have access to movies, rent TV shows and download game add-ons. The PS3 also has a host of exclusive game series restricted to its platform, popular among which are *Resistance*, *God of War*, *Killzone*, *Uncharted*, *inFamous* and *Gran Turismo*. These are not only some of the most popular games on the PS3 but in the gaming fraternity as a whole.

In answer to the Nintendo Wii, PS3 released the Move, its very own motion controller back in September 2010. Playing with the Wii remote and Move is nearly the same, with PS3's superior graphics and precision game control offering slightly better overall user experience for motion-controlled games. Also, the number of gaming titles requiring the Move bundle to tailor a unique gaming experience continue to grow.

The PS3 Slim 160GB recently slashed its prices down to ₹16,990.

Microsoft Xbox 360

If you were to ask me that one overwhelming reason why one should buy an Xbox 360 over the Sony PS3 or Nintendo Wii, it would have to be this — Xbox Live. Microsoft's unbeatable online gaming experience paired with a whole host of entertainment content makes Xbox Live a comprehensive online entertainment destination. It does demand a yearly premium of \$50 (about ₹2,400) but its 20 million plus annual subscribers don't seem to mind the service they get — games, betas, movies, TV shows and more. And Xbox Live has a thriving community of online gamers.

In terms of user interface, the Xbox 360 is in between the Nintendo Wii (simplest) and Sony PS3 (extensive). It probably enjoys the most extensive game library among all three consoles, and like the PS3 gives a steady number of game "exclusives" like *Halo*, *Gears of War*, *Forza* and *Fable*.

In terms of motion controllers, the Xbox 360 has done one better than Wii and PS3. With Kinect — Xbox 360's exclusive motion controller — you don't need to hold a wand to control a game, the controller scans your body movement to interpret it as actions. It adds a host of casual, fitness games to the Xbox 360's library.

All things considered, I still wonder which one to buy for myself. I could go with any of the above mentioned consoles. Write in to give me your views on which console you'd go for and the reason why. 